

Problem Interview Script: Agricultural Compliance Platform

PART 1: CONSULTANT & EXTENSION SERVICE PRE-SCREENING

INTERVIEW OBJECTIVES Validate whether compliance record-keeping is a top-3 client pain point. Confirm channel viability and willingness to recommend solutions.

TARGET PROFILE Ag consultants, crop advisors, and extension service representatives in Missouri and surrounding states who work with licensed applicators.

DURATION: 20-30 minutes via video call or phone **RECORDING:** Request permission. Take handwritten notes.

OPENING SCRIPT 'Thanks for taking time today. We're exploring whether compliance record-keeping is a pain point for applicators you work with. This is exploratory—no sales pitch. Just trying to understand the real challenges. Does that work?'

CONSULTANT INTERVIEW: OPENING & CONTEXT (5 min)

1. 'Tell me about the applicators or farms you typically advise. What's your relationship like?' • Listen for: Size of operations, types of crops, frequency of contact
2. 'In a typical season, what are the top 3 challenges your clients bring to you?' • DO NOT suggest compliance—let them define priorities • Listen for: What's unprompted vs. what you prompt
3. 'How involved are you in helping clients manage EPA compliance and record-keeping?' • Listen for: Current role, level of engagement, frustration points

CONSULTANT INTERVIEW: PAIN DISCOVERY (10 min)

1. 'When it comes to documenting pesticide or herbicide applications, what challenges do you see your clients facing?' • Follow-up: 'Can you give me a specific example?' • Listen for: Manual record-keeping, scattered data, audit anxiety
2. 'How much of your advisory time goes toward helping clients organize or prepare compliance documentation?' • Follow-up: 'How do they feel about that process?' • Listen for: Time burden, client frustration signals
3. 'Have any of your clients faced compliance audits or regulatory issues?' • Follow-up: 'What happened? How did it affect them?' • Listen for: Fines, operational disruption, emotional impact

CONSULTANT INTERVIEW: CURRENT SOLUTIONS & GAPS (5 min)

1. 'How do your clients currently track and document their applications?' • Listen for: Paper, spreadsheets, software, no system
2. 'What's working about their current approach? What's not?' • Follow-up: 'If you could design the ideal solution, what would it include?' • Listen for: Desired features, integration needs, pain points
3. 'Would your clients benefit from a mobile-first compliance tool that works offline?' • Listen for: Interest level, skepticism, feature feedback

CONSULTANT INTERVIEW: CHANNEL & PARTNERSHIP (5 min)

1. 'If we built a solution that addressed the challenges you mentioned, would you be interested in recommending it to your clients?' • Listen for: Genuine interest vs. polite interest • Follow-up: 'What would you need to see before recommending?'
2. 'Would you be willing to introduce us to 3–5 clients who face these challenges?' • Listen for: Yes/Maybe/No; conditions; willingness to vouch
3. 'How would a partnership work best—referrals, co-marketing, white-label integration?' • Listen for: Preferred model, revenue-share interest

CONSULTANT INTERVIEW: CLOSING (5 min)

1. 'Is there anything else about compliance challenges or solutions that I should know?' • Listen for: Unexpected insights or concerns

CLOSING SCRIPT 'This has been really helpful. Based on what you've shared, it sounds like [summarize]. Does that match your experience? If we built a tool addressing [specific problem], would you be interested in introducing us to clients who face this?'

THANK YOU Express genuine appreciation. Share next steps if appropriate. Ask for referrals to other consultants worth talking to.

PART 2: APPLICATOR PROBLEM INTERVIEW SCRIPT

INTERVIEW OBJECTIVES Understand applicators' current compliance workflow, pain points, and willingness to adopt a solution. Identify early adopters. Validate or challenge your problem statement.

TARGET PROFILE Licensed pesticide applicators or farm operators who apply EPA-regulated products in Missouri and surrounding states.

DURATION: 20-30 minutes via video call RECORDING: Request permission. Take handwritten notes.

APPROACH For warm intros from consultants: Reference the consultant by name. For cold outreach: Acknowledge you found them through extension services or industry connections.

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: OPENING & CONTEXT (5 min)

1. 'Tell me about your operation—what do you grow, how many acres, and how many applications do you do per season?' • Listen for: Operation size, complexity, scale
2. 'Walk me through a typical spray season for you. What's your workflow look like from start to finish?' • Listen for: Sequence of activities, tools used, pain points
3. 'Besides farming, what's taking up most of your time right now?' • Listen for: Top priorities and pain points (not assuming compliance)

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: PROBLEM DISCOVERY (10 min)

1. 'When you apply pesticides or herbicides, how do you currently document and track those applications?' • Follow-up: 'Walk me through that process. How long does it take?' • Listen for: Tools, time burden, frustration
2. 'What's the most frustrating part of managing compliance records?' • Follow-up: 'Has that caused problems for you?' • Listen for: Specific pain, emotional language, consequences
3. 'How often do you think about EPA compliance rules when you're applying products?' • Follow-up: 'Ever worried you might be doing something wrong?' • Listen for: Confidence level, anxiety signals

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: PROBLEM DEPTH (5 min)

1. 'Have you ever had an audit, inspection, or compliance issue?' • Follow-up if yes: 'What happened? How did it affect you?' • Listen for: Financial impact, emotional reaction, behavior change • Follow-up if no: 'Have you heard about peers getting fined?'
2. 'On a scale of 1-10, how concerned are you about compliance right now?' • Follow-up: 'What would make that concern go away?' • Listen for: Urgency level, solution appetite
3. 'If you could eliminate one pain point in your operation, what would it be?' • Listen for: Whether compliance is top 3 or lower priority

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: CURRENT SOLUTIONS (5 min)

1. 'How satisfied are you with your current approach to tracking and documenting applications?' • Follow-up: 'What's not working about it?' • Listen for: Satisfaction level, specific gaps
2. 'Have you ever tried other tools or methods to manage compliance?' • Follow-up: 'Why did you stop using it?' • Listen for: Experience with solutions, switching reasons
3. 'What would an ideal compliance solution look like for you?' • Follow-up: 'Would you want it on your phone, computer, or both?' • Listen for: Feature preferences, platform preferences, must-haves

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: VALUE & WILLINGNESS TO PAY (5 min)

1. 'How much time per season do you currently spend on compliance record-keeping?' • Follow-up: 'At your hourly rate, what's that time worth?' • Listen for: Time quantified, cost impact
2. 'If you got audited tomorrow, how prepared would you be to show documentation?' • Follow-up: 'What would it take to feel fully prepared?' • Listen for: Confidence, anxiety, value perception
3. 'If there was a tool that cut your record-keeping time in half AND gave you peace of mind about compliance, what would you pay for it annually?' • Listen for: Price anchors, hesitation, genuine willingness • Follow-up: 'Would that be worth it to you?'

APPLICATOR INTERVIEW: CLOSING & REFERRALS (5 min)

1. 'Is there anything else about managing compliance or documentation that I should know?' • Listen for: Unexpected concerns or opportunities

REFERRAL REQUEST 'You've been really helpful. Do you know 2–3 other applicators I could talk to about their compliance challenges? I'm trying to understand if this is a widespread problem.'

CLOSING SCRIPT 'Thanks for walking me through this. It sounds like [summarize their workflow and pain]. If we built a tool that addressed [specific problem they mentioned], would you be interested in testing it during your next season?'

EARLY ADOPTER SIGNAL Listen for: 'Yes, I'd test it' = Early adopter. 'Maybe, if it proves itself' = Fence-sitter. 'No thanks' = Not a fit.

POST-INTERVIEW DATA CAPTURE

Immediately after each interview, complete this template while fresh:

PROBLEM INTENSITY (1-10 scale) 1 = Doesn't really care about compliance 10 = Actively anxious, ready to change now

EARLY ADOPTER SIGNALS (Check all that apply) ☐ Recent compliance scare or audit ☐ Actively using digital tools ☐ Frustrated with current system ☐ Tech-comfortable, younger demographic ☐ Willing to test new solutions ☐ Would evangelize to peers

WILLINGNESS TO PAY Amount they named: \$_____/month Confidence: (High / Medium / Low)

TOP PAIN POINT Direct quote about their #1 problem: _____

SOLUTION FEEDBACK Preferred approach: (Mobile / Web / Integrated / Consultant-managed) Must-have features: _____

NEXT ACTIONS ☐ Would test MVP ☐ Willing to be reference customer ☐ Referred other applicators ☐
No further interest

GREEN/YELLOW/RED FLAG SCORING

GREEN FLAGS (Strong Validation) • Unprompted mentions of compliance challenge • Specific time/cost spent on current process • Recent audit or peer fine story • Immediate excitement about your solution • Names price without hesitation • Asks when it's available • Offers to refer peers

YELLOW FLAGS (Weak Validation) • Agrees compliance is problem when prompted • Vague descriptions ('Yeah, it's a hassle') • No recent compliance issue • Would 'consider' but not excited • Uncertain about price • Asks for proof/references first • Suggests consultant recommendation needed

RED FLAGS (Invalidation) • Says compliance isn't really their problem • Manages fine with current system • Haven't thought about it much • Would only pay \$10-20/month or expects free • Says they'd need to see it adopted by peers • No digital tool adoption, resistant to change • Problem ranks below #5 in priorities

INTERVIEW STRATEGY & TIPS

LISTENING RATIO: Aim for 70% listening, 30% talking

ASK OPEN QUESTIONS Weak: 'Is compliance difficult?' Strong: 'Tell me about your current process.'

SIT WITH SILENCE After asking a question, pause. Let them think. Don't fill the void.

PRESS ON CONTRADICTIONS If they say 'It's not a big problem' but 'I spend 15 hours on it per season,' ask: 'Help me understand—that sounds like a lot of time.'

NOTICE UNPROMPTED VS. PROMPTED What they bring up without you asking is more important than what they mention when you probe.

WATCH FOR EMOTIONAL SIGNALS Listen for: Frustration, anxiety, resignation, excitement. These signal problem importance.

TAKE NOTES DURING CALL Don't just record. Active note-taking shows respect and captures nuance.

DON'T SELL Your job is learning, not pitching. If they ask 'When can I use this?', say: 'That's what

we're trying to figure out based on what we learn from people like you.'

SCORE IMMEDIATELY AFTER While memory is fresh, complete the data capture template. Pattern recognition happens when reviewing all interviews together.